

Storytelling - Learning of institutional capacity building: Estonia's experience

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BEGINNING — A Story About Building Systems That Outlast People

My name is Cris-Tiina Pärn. For the last eleven years I have coordinated Estonia's greenhouse gas reporting, first at the Ministry of Environment, now at the Estonian Environmental Research Centre. I want to tell you a story about what that has taught me about maintaining and improving a national reporting systems and building the capacity that keeps it running.

Estonia is a country of 1.3 million people. Smaller than many European cities.

It has one ministry handling what larger countries would distribute across four or five. The people who write the reports are often the same who defend it internationally, train the next generation of experts, and answer the phone when a data provider calls with a question. When someone leaves, the gap is real and immediate.

And yet Estonia reports. It reports accurately, on time, in full compliance with its international obligations, year after year. Its submissions are credible. Its methodology is documented. Its data chains are traceable. When a reviewer asks a question, someone can answer it.

How? Not through large teams or extensive resources, but through something more deliberate: the right systems, applied consistently, by people who understood that in a small country, institutional design is a practical necessity. You cannot afford to keep knowledge in one person's head, and you cannot afford to rebuild from scratch every time a government changes. So, you build processes that are larger than any individual.

Estonia is, in this sense, an instructive starting point for a conversation about institutional capacity building — not because it is perfect, but because it demonstrates that what matters is not how many people you have, but how well the system holds when those people change.

MIDDLE — The Hard Part No One Likes to Talk About

This is not just a story I observed from the outside. It is a story I have been part of.

When I joined the Ministry of Environment in 2015, the national system for GHG inventories was already in place. The essence of the system, the logic of it, had been established. What I inherited from my predecessor was not chaos. It was a foundation that needed updating, not rebuilding. **And that, I think, is part of the point:** a good system does not need to be reinvented with every new person who walks through the door. **It needs to be maintained, understood, and gradually improved.**

At that time, the Ministry was handling not just coordination but all the QA and QC work as well. Over time it became clear that this highly technical work sat a bit awkwardly in a ministry as the real technical expertise lived in institutions preparing the calculations, including at the Estonian Environmental Research Centre.

So, in 2018, coordination of GHG reporting moved to EERC. The technical team gained the standing that matched their role. The Ministry's public servants gained space to focus on what genuinely needed ministerial attention: policy, political relationships, the issues that require the weight of a public institution behind them.

And 2018 brought something else as well: the EU Governance Regulation.

Before that, GHG reporting in Estonia, as across the EU, was governed by the so called MMR regulation (Monitoring Mechanism Regulation). That framework worked, but it kept different reporting streams in separate lanes. Energy efficiency here. Renewables there. GHG emissions somewhere else. Different deadlines, different templates, different conversations, different groups of people who rarely sat in the same room.

The Governance Regulation changed that. It brought those streams together and in doing so it built capacity in a way no training programme had managed.

It did three things at once.

- 1) It forced energy, renewables and GHG teams to understand each other's work and see how the data connected.
- 2) It gave us a single deadline and a single framework to organise around, which meant the same or similar procedures.
- 3) And it made data quality everyone's problem, not just the inventory team's — because under one regulation, a weakness in one stream visibly drags down the others.

That is how capacity is built in practice. By giving them a structure that requires them to work together, year after year, on something that has to add up.

It was difficult at first — different communities, different methodologies, suddenly required to produce coherent reporting under a single framework. But those honest conversations produced something real: a shared understanding of why data quality matters, not as an abstract principle, **but as a practical reality that affects whether energy and climate policy is well-designed, whether financial planning is grounded in credible projections.** Public servants who had seen GHG reporting as a niche technical obligation began to understand it as connected to decisions that actually matter.

The Governance Regulation gave us the framework. But two decisions made at home mattered just as much.

- **First**, putting the right work in the right institution. By moving coordination to EERC in 2018 we recognised that technical work belongs with the technical experts, and ministerial work belongs at the ministry.
- **Second**, treating each reporting cycle as a chance to improve, after every submission we ask ourselves, what worked well this year, and how do we fix it before the next one?

And now, in 2026, the reporting continues. The inventory work goes on. But Estonia has taken significant steps forward with its policies and measures reporting, its projections, and the broader set of reporting streams that fall under the Governance Regulation. The system that seemed adequate in 2015 has grown into something more comprehensive and more integrated.

THE BROADER LESSON — What Estonia Taught Me About Everywhere Else

I am telling this story not because Estonia is the most advanced country in Europe in reporting. Not because its system is perfect. But because it is the right size of example.

When people in small countries or with thin expert pools and constrained budgets hear about best practice from big EU countries with teams two or three times the size, something understandable happens: they nod politely and quietly conclude that it does not apply to them. The scale is different.

The resources are different. The institutional history is different. The example, however instructive in theory, does not feel reachable. Estonia feels reachable.

A country of 1.3 million people, a team of ten, operating under the same EU frameworks that apply to you — and producing credible and compliant reports and improving reporting year after year. That is not an abstract model. That is a concrete demonstration that the size of your country and the size of your team are not the binding constraints they might appear to be.

And the most important thing Estonia demonstrates is that the system does not need to be perfect before it starts working. It needs to start.

For us in 2015, the national system was already in place, but it was not finished. It has been continuously updated, reorganised, extended. The institutional arrangements shifted in 2018. The legal framework changed with the Governance Regulation. New reporting streams were brought in. Old procedures were revised. None of this happened at once. It happened step by step, cycle by cycle, year by year.

That is what institutional capacity building actually looks like from the inside. Not a project with a start date and an end date. Not a system that is designed, delivered, and declared complete. A continuous process of asking: what did not work well this cycle, and how do we make it work better next time?

Countries in this room are at different points in that journey. What Estonia shows is that you do not need to solve everything at once. You need to know which problem **you are solving now**, solve it well enough to move forward, and build on it next time.

END — What This Means for Us, Here, Now

Many of you might be working in exactly the position Estonia was in ten or fifteen years ago.

Small teams, multitasking to max. These are real constraints, and they sit alongside real obligations.

If there is one thing I want you to take from this story, it is this:

what determines whether your institution succeeds over time is not how many people you have, but whether the knowledge lives in the system or only in individuals — whether the process survives a change of government and a change of staff.

Estonia became capable because it chose to build something that would outlast any individual: a system that holds, that learns, that improves, and that is still there long after the people who built it have moved on.

The question is not whether it can be done. The question is whether you are ready to build it.